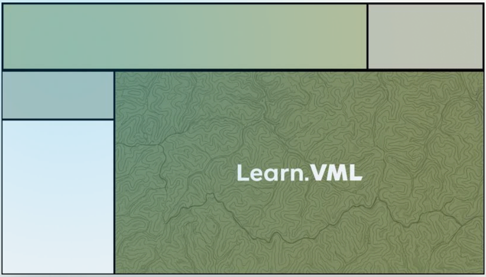
Marve Afo
Product designer

VML

Turning a Junk Drawer Into a Design System



T.L.D.R.

Rebuilt VML's global LMS from a nav-less 'junk drawer' into a coded, design system.

- Drove 89% org-wide adoption
- 316% more learning time
- 230% more active users

Role

Sole product and visual designer
on a six-person learning team,
reporting to the Global VP of Learning.

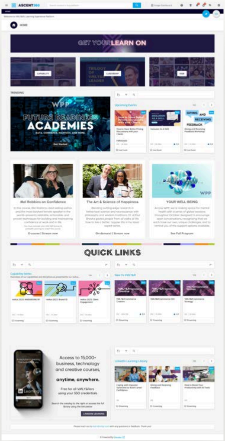
Key Stakeholders

- VP, Global Head of Learning
- Global Director of HR Technology
- Regional Learning Directors

Sneak Peek

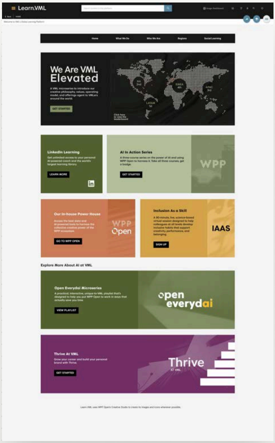
Before

Original home page


ASCENT360
HOME
GET YOUR LEARN ON
TRENDING
WPP
FUTURE READINESS
ACADEMIES
DATA, COMMERCE, MARTECH, AND MORE.
Get Started
Upcoming Events
GIVING AND RECEIVING FEEDBACK
Mel Robbins on Confidence
E-course | Stream now
The Art & Science of Happiness
On-demand | Stream now
YOUR WELL-BEING
See Full Program
QUICK LINKS
Capability Series
New To VMLY&R
VMLY&R Commerce Creative
VMLY&R Commerce CCX
VML Y&R Commerce Strategy
Access to 15,000+ business, technology and creative courses,
anytime, anywhere.
Free for all VMLY&Rers using your SSO credentials.
LinkedIn Learning
LINKEDIN LEARNING
LinkedIn Learning Library

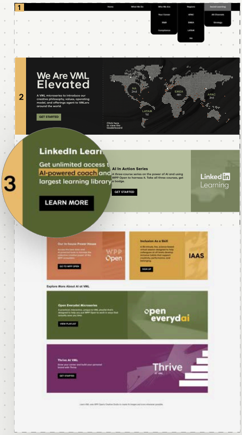
After

Revised home page


Learn.VML
Home
What We Do
Who We Are
Regions
Social Learning
We Are VML Elevated
GET STARTED
LinkedIn Learning
LEARN MORE
AI In Action Series
GET STARTED
WPP
Our In-house Power House
GO TO WPP OPEN
WPP Open
Inclusion As a Skill
SIGN UP
IAAS
Explore More About AI at VML
Open Everydai Microseries
VIEW PLAYLIST
open everydai
Thrive At VML
GET STARTED
Thrive
AT VML

A Closer Look

Revised home page with highlighted callouts


1
2
3
NA
2nd
EMEA
4th
APAC
3rd
LATAM
1st

We Are VML
Elevated

A VML microseries to introduce our creative philosophy, values, operating model, and offerings agent to VMLers around the world.

GET STARTED

Click here to view the leaderboard

LinkedIn Learn

Get unlimited access t
AI-powered coach and
largest learning library

LEARN MORE

AI In Action Series

A three-course series on the power of AI and using WPP Open to harness it. Take all three courses, get a badge.

GET STARTED

Linked in Learning

WPP Open

Inclusion As a Skill

IAAS

Explore More About AI at VML

open everydai

Thrive At VML

Thrive

What Changed

Same Page, New System

1) Real navigation
A coded nav bar replaced links buried inside links.

2) New hero
A customizable coded hero spotlights one initiative instead of competing banners.

3) Real text
Headlines and descriptions are live text, so search can find them.

Fewer cards
Organized content rows replaced dozens of scattered tiles.

One block system
Every section uses the same component library, so pages stay consistent.

Branded throughout
VML colors, textures, and the custom font run site-wide.

Clear CTAs
One consistent button style across every section.

The Problem

Leadership Called It A Junk Drawer

Unorganized
VML's learning platform had no main navigation, just links buried inside links. Leadership called it a junk drawer. For a creative agency that sells branded experiences, a platform that looked like an afterthought undercut the very learning it asked employees to take seriously.

Then VMLY&R merged with Wunderman Thompson to become VML. That meant two legacy LMSs, a new brand kit, and new leadership, all needed one platform to teach employees who the new company was.

4 Step Fix

Audit

Systemize

Brand

Customize

UX Audit

An Audit Highlighted 3 Failures

Before redesigning anything, I ran a heuristic audit, clicking through the platform as a new employee would and annotating screenshots wherever the experience broke down.

It was hard to find pages
There was no main navigation, search was easy to miss and laid out backwards. Many courses were buried in links inside links.
There was not a clear info heiarchy.

The interface didn't explain itself
Icons were misleading (the "add content" icon looked like an email reply), labels were vague ("Share this view?"), and there were two filter buttons doing one job.

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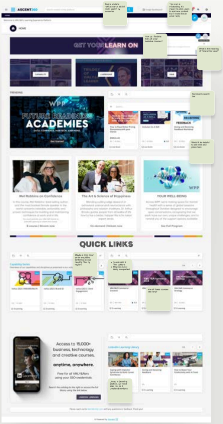

GET YOUR LEARN ON
FUTURE READINESS ACADEMIES
QUICK LINKS
Access to 15,000+ business, technology and creative courses, anytime, anywhere.

Took a while to notice search. Wish I could search by instructor

Misleading icon. It's meant to allow users to add new content but looks like email reply

How do I find the 100s of other available courses?

What is the meaning of "Share this view?"

Backwards search bar

Would it be helpful to see time and place here?

Maybe a drop down arrow would be better but do we need to filter by region?

Are all these courses still new?

Do we need 2 filter buttons? This icon is not easily interpreted?

Linked In Learning section...My mind sees this as 2 unrelated modules

The Constraints

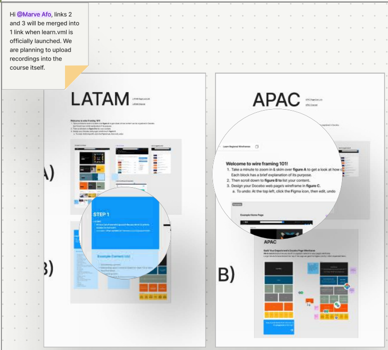
4 Blocks, No Nav, No Custom Fonts.

Limited customization
This needed real information architecture, not a new coat of style. Docebo locked us into fixed content blocks, with no native navigation and no way to load our own fonts. Whatever we built had to work inside those walls.

Drawing Board

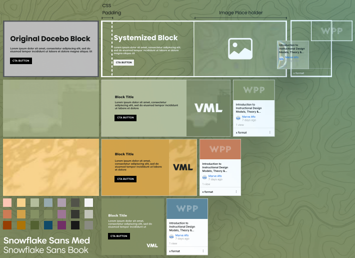
I Fixed Structure Before Style

With the audit done, I facilitated a session introducing learning directors from four global regions to FigJam, so we could share and compare sitemap needs in one place. I then helped each region build lo-fi mockups of their own LMS pages.



Hi @Marve Afo, links 2 and 3 will be merged into 1 link when learn.vml is launched. We are planning to upload recordings into the course itself.

LATAM
A)
B)
STEP 1
APAC
Welcome to wire framing 101!
B)



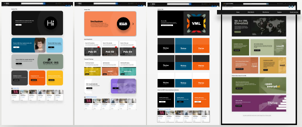
CSS
Padding
Image Place holder
Original Docebo Block
CTA BUTTON
Systemized Block
CTA BUTTON
WPP
Block Title
CTA BUTTON
VML
WPP
Introduction to Instructional Design Models, Theory &...
Marve Afo
Block Title
CTA BUTTON
VML
WPP
Block Title
CTA BUTTON
VML
WPP
Snowflake Sans Med
Snowflake Sans Book

I Turned Limits Into a System

I reverse engineered Docebo's content blocks in Figma, measuring the real thing so anything I built translated exactly when shipped. I systemized the four block sizes into a lego-like component library with swap-in textures and swatches from the new **VML** brand kit, built all 14 core pages for the post-merger relaunch, enabling fast, consistent mockups for easy sharing and approval.

Again and Again

I did many iterations of branding and design before reaching the current product.



Hi
Inclusion
VML
Thrive

The Decisions

Readable Text Made Learning Findable

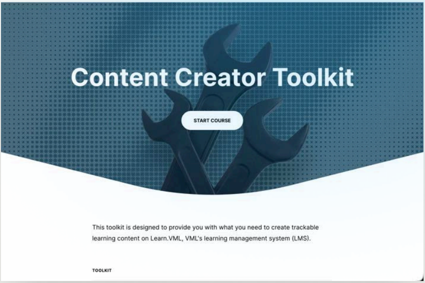
The old platform rendered most of its text as images. That meant no search, and no screen reader support. I rebuilt everything as real, readable text. Not a stylistic choice.
A functional one.

Fewer Cards Made Pages Faster

Certain key pages were trying to load up to fifty content cards at once. It wasn't just cluttered, it was slow. I restructured all main pages into one hero block, a handful of organized content block rows, and a single channel feed at the bottom. Fixed the mess and the load time in the same move.

Governance Made the System Last

Good design can't fix active misuse on its own. The team built tagging rules with regional leads owning them; I built the training that made it stick, teaching teams exactly how to organize what they uploaded so better tagging meant content actually got found.

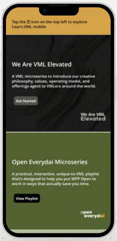

Content Creator Toolkit
START COURSE

This toolkit is designed to provide you with what you need to create trackable learning content on Learn.VML, VML's learning management system (LMS).

TOOLKIT

1 Block for Mobile

I redesigned every page for mobile using a single block: the smallest of Docebo's four sizes. It fit the screen perfectly, so stacking it gave every page a clean, consistent layout that kept the branding and hierarchy intact.


Tap the ☰ icon on the top left to explore Learn.VML mobile

We Are VML Elevated

A VML microseries to introduce our creative philosophy, values, operating model, and offerings agent to VMLers around the world.

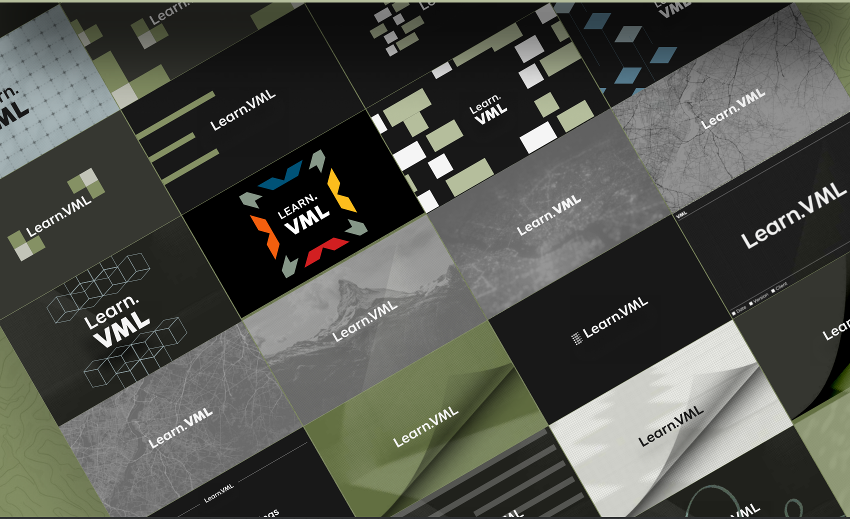
Get Started
We Are VML Elevated

Open Everydai Microseries

A practical, interactive, unique-to-VML playlist that's designed to help you put WPP Open to work in ways that actually save you time.

View Playlist
open everydai

The Brand Couldn't Look Like Training
It had to make people want to click. I started in black and white to avoid color bias, testing textures from paper to foundational bricks. With VML's VP, Global Head of Learning, we landed on elevation: growth, told through map topography and VML's full color palette.


Learn.VML
LEARN. VML
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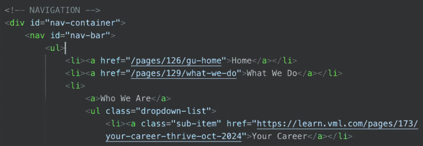
Learn. VML

Customization

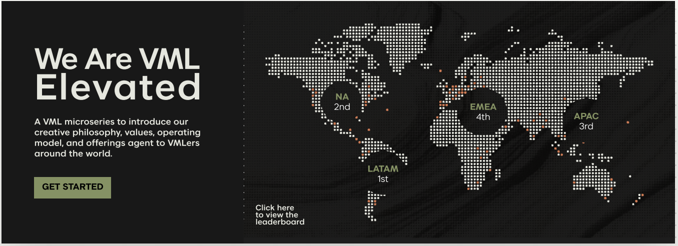
Where The LMS Stopped, I Coded

Docebo had no navigation bar or flexible hero section, so I coded both in HTML. The new hero held video, leaderboards, larger images, and longer copy, allowing room to promote initiatives like our Brandon Hall Award–winning Microlearning Challenge that brought nearly 12K visits in three months, triple the usual monthly traffic.

I pulled CSS selectors in dev tools to fix spacing platform-wide with my own code, and embedded VML's custom font via base64, giving every page the brand voice the platform's limits once constrained.



```
<!-- NAVIGATION -->
<div id="nav-container">
    <nav id="nav-bar">
        <ul>
            <li><a href="/pages/126/gu-home">Home</a></li>
            <li><a href="/pages/129/what-we-do">What We Do</a></li>
            <li>
                <a>Who We Are</a>
                <ul class="dropdown-list">
                    <li><a class="sub-item" href="https://learn.vml.com/pages/173/
                    your-career-thrive-oct-2024">Your Career</a></li>
```



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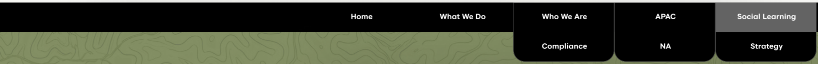
GET STARTED

NA
2nd
EMEA
4th
APAC
3rd
LATAM
1st
Click here to view the leaderboard


Home
What We Do
Who We Are
APAC
Social Learning
Compliance
NA
Strategy

89% Showed Up. Then They Stayed.

Stats reflect the first 10 months after launch.

89%	of employees logged in at least once
316%	increase in average learning time per user versus the old platform
230%	increase in unique monthly users compared to both legacy platforms combined
+431	additional courses created by regional teams, all inside the system

431 Courses Later, No Junk Drawer

What I'd Do Differently
I'd go back and properly name, tag, and organize my Figma layers after every big push. I spent this project teaching teams that good tagging is what makes content findable. My own files deserved the same rule. Clean layers would have made every later project, from branding new learning initiatives to new LMS pages, faster to build from.

2+ Years In
Revamping the LMS was my first major project at VML. It's since been at the heart of 10+ awards for the learning team, including Brandon Hall and even Docebo itself. The real test of a design system isn't launch day. It's whether it holds when other people start building. So far, so good.